COCAINE

Also known as coke, charlie, blow or snow

KNOW THE RISKS
Cocaine is a powerful stimulant. It can cause dependence and serious harm to the heart, brain and mental health - even after occasional use.

What is cocaine?

Cocaine is a Class A drug, often seen as a white powder. It may be snorted, smoked or injected. You cannot reliably know its strength or what has been mixed into it.

How can cocaine affect you?

Immediate effects: A short burst of energy or confidence can be followed by anxiety, panic, agitation, paranoia, a racing heart or raised blood pressure.

Heart and brain: Cocaine can cause dangerous heart rhythms, heart attacks, strokes or seizures, sometimes after a single use.

Dependence and comedown: Repeated use can lead to cravings and difficulty stopping. Afterwards, people may feel exhausted, low, irritable or unable to sleep.

Mixing cocaine with alcohol

Using cocaine and alcohol together creates **cocaethylene** in the body, raising the risk of heart problems and other serious harm. Mixing drugs can make effects unpredictable.

EMERGENCY WARNING SIGNS
Chest pain, collapse, seizure, severe headache, difficulty breathing, overheating or sudden weakness or confusion: **call 999 immediately.**

THE KEY MESSAGE
A short-lived high can have serious consequences. Ask for help early, without shame or judgement.

RECOGNISE THE SIGNS. GET HELP EARLY.

Practical information for individuals, parents and families.

When to seek urgent help

Call **999** for chest pain, collapse, seizures, severe breathing problems or signs of a stroke. Tell paramedics what may have been taken. Do not leave someone who is unconscious alone.

What you can do

If cocaine is affecting sleep, mood, money, work or relationships, speak to a GP or local drug service. Families: ask calm questions, listen first and avoid blame. Never drive while affected.

UK law | England and Wales

Cocaine is a **Class A controlled drug.**

POSSESSION: Up to **7 years in prison**, an unlimited fine, or both.

SELLING OR SUPPLYING: Up to **life imprisonment**, an unlimited fine, or both.

DRUG-DRIVING: A **minimum 1-year driving ban**, up to 6 months in prison, an unlimited fine and a criminal record.

Prison terms are maximum penalties. Driving over the specified cocaine blood limit can be an offence even without obvious impairment.

Families, stigma and support

Cocaine use may be hidden through fear, embarrassment or concerns about family honour. Support someone without shame or threats. **Families and carers deserve support too.**

Free local support in Rochdale

TURNING POINT / ROAR | Adults: drug and alcohol support
0300 555 0234

EARLY BREAK | Young people and families
0161 723 3880

THE SALIK PROJECT UK | Community education and help finding support
contact@salikprojectuk.org

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

Sources: NHS cocaine information; GOV.UK drug penalties and drug-driving law; NHS guidance on cocaine and alcohol. Reviewed November 2026.